

Is A Digital Camera As Good As Camcorder?

Most digital still cameras can shoot videos, and most camcorders can shoot stills, but are these designed to do both at the same level?



Nikon S620 digital camera

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The distinction between digital cameras and camcorders seems to be blurring with digital cameras also shooting videos and camcorders also shooting stills. This leaves many a prospective buyer wondering which is a better purchase, a digital camera or camcorder.

Let's find the answer.

How do the two compare?

First and foremost, try to understand that digital cameras and camcorders

are completely different equipment meant for different purposes and therefore the technology used in them differs widely. Although most digital still cameras can shoot videos, and most camcorders can shoot stills, these are generally not designed to do both at the same level. Both have their pros and cons.

Still image capture and video recording quality. The sensor and image processor of digital still cameras are designed to process still images, so these will always have a better picture quality for still pictures. Besides, digital cameras offer still images with a very high

resolution (minimum 8 to 10 megapixels nowadays). Special preset modes allow for best quality in different situations like portrait, night and landscape. Also, the specialised software embedded in digital cameras ensures true image quality in different scenes.

On the other hand, although any good-quality digital still camera can shoot videos (even high-definition (HD) video at 720p), the quality will often not match that of a mid-range camcorder. This is due to dedicated design of the camcorder's sensor and image processor that can process at constant frame rate.

Lenses/zoom and other hardware. Chandrakanth Kamath, assistant manager-sales and technical support, Nikon India, says that although many digital still cameras nowadays have very high optical zooming ratios (up to 24x), most camcorders offer a higher zooming range (30x to 60x). This, again, is due to the difference in technology used and the format.

Most cameras do not use zoom during video recording, while some offer digital zoom. This is done to avoid the sound of the lens motor disturbing the video clip. However, camcorders do not suffer from this disadvantage.

Digital camcorders have a vari-angle (tilting) LCD monitor, in addition to an electronic viewfinder. These features are not present in most digital still cameras.

Storage media options. Most digital cameras use flash memory cards to record still and video images. However, recording time is often limited to